heading back towards its main defences. Around the same time, 2 Sikh LI was ordered by its commanding officer to abandon its defences and start moving through the 1 Sikh positions to start its withdrawal towards Nyukmadong. As the Sikh LI troops began to pull out, they were fired upon by Chinese jitter parties.

1 Sikh had not been told that that 2 Sikh withdrawal had been advanced by a day. A wave of panic spread through 1 Sikh at the sudden appearance of 2 Sikh LI amidst its defences. In the process, 1 Sikh troops also began to abandon their defences leading to complete chaos on Se-la Top.

Hoshiar Singh was furious with Irani for having pulled 2 Sikh LI out prematurely from the defences around Kye-la. The early pull-out not only sealed the fate of 4 Sikh LI, it gave the Chinese a walkover on what should have been their Waterloo. Had 4 Sikh LI occupied their defences by the time 2 Sikh LI withdrew, the Chinese troops on their tail would have walked into a death trap.

By the time Hoshiar Singh realized the extent of the damage, 1 Sikh and 2 Sikh LI were milling around in complete confusion. At 4 a.m., Hoshiar Singh spoke to Pathania: ‘Something awful has happened. 1 Sikh are withdrawing and Se-la defences are gone. I am going up to stop them.’ This was the last time Hoshiar Singh and Pathania were to speak, for line communication between 62 Brigade and 4 Division HQ broke down shortly thereafter. At Se-la Top, the brigade commander realized the hopelessness of the situation. Left with no choice other than to legitimize the withdrawal, orders were given to fall back on Senge-Dzong. By then the leading elements of the Chinese had inserted themselves between 4 Sikh LI (plus elements of 7 Mahar) and the rest of the brigade. Hoshiar Singh had no choice but to abandon the battalion to its fate.

To cover the withdrawal of 4 Garhwal, Delta Company of 4 Sikh LI had been tasked with occupying a screen position at KM 108. This would also allow it to cover the pullback of Alpha and Charlie Companies of its own battalion that were coming down from Tsogiya Lake and re-deploying at Se-la. Accordingly, the Garhwalis went through Delta Company at 2 a.m. and Alpha and Charlie followed at 4.50 a.m., after which Delta Company was also ordered to fall back.

As Delta Company made their way up the Nuranang–Se-la axis, it found Alpha and Charlie Companies astride the road at KM 102. Both these companies had come under heavy fire as they approached their original